



WYRMHOLE

Picocon 43

Cover by Rebecca Allday

https://www.instagram.com/wizard_scrawls

A Word from Our Overlord

Welcome to Picocon 43!

Picocon is our very own annual convention and is a time to celebrate both Sci-Fi and Fantasy with a variety of exciting events and guest speakers.

I want to start by giving a massive thank you to our Picocon Sofa, Raj, and our Picocon Beanbag, Sam, for their diligent work in organising this event. I also wish to thank all of the other committee members for their work in organising and running events as well as keeping our library running smoothly. It has been great working with everyone, and I look forward to continuing to do with most of you next year. I also look forward to working with some of our upcoming, and returning, committee members.

This year brought us many challenges, such as the library ceiling foiling some of our plans for fresher's week, and most of us being new to the committee, but we have persevered and worked to keep the society going and exploring new avenues to take it forward.

Thank you for joining us at Picocon and for being a part of this society. Thank you all for coming.

ΨΦ

Mateusz Sejda
ICSF Entity of Chairs



icsf.org.uk



facebook.com/groups/ICSF.imperial
Sci-fi talk, news and events, entertaining links.



[@picocon](https://twitter.com/picocon)
Announcements and hype for our annual convention.



[@Imperial_SciFi](https://twitter.com/Imperial_SciFi)
Our official, formerly Blue bird app account thing.



[@imperial_scifi](https://www.instagram.com/imperial_scifi)
Visions from the library.

The Sofa's Ramblings

Hello all! Welcome to Picocon 43. This is your Sofa, Rajveer, a second year physicist. This year's theme is Wyrmhole, sounds mysterious doesn't it? Any guesses as to its origin?

It's just a pun on wormholes...

The idea was to have a theme covering sci-fi and fantasy with significant elements involving Space. But condensing that into a singular word was difficult. Thankfully, this year's Chair of Vice, Michael, came up with a cool name.

After all, Wyrmhole brings together two ideas that show up constantly in science fiction and fantasy: wyrms, an old name for dragons, and holes of all kinds, from black holes, wormholes, and portals to the interdimensional rift.

In the morning, we will begin with a talk from Drew Wagar is RSM 228, where he will talk about "Building Worlds:"

"I'll be taking the audience behind the scenes of the Shadeward Saga (with a few side quests into Elite) to show how a single idea developed into a living, internally consistent universe. Blending hard science with mythic storytelling, I'll explore how world-building begins with asking the right questions – and how imagination, discipline and curiosity can grow into entire civilisations."

After this, Paul McAuley will give a talk about portals in sci-fi and how he explored these and other concepts in the Jackaroo series.

Next, we will break for lunch at about 12:00. We will separate to get food on campus or from the various restaurants in South Kensington. Feel free to ask the committee for any recommendations.

Around 12:30, we will begin the Baguette Bash (on Queen's Lawn hopefully). Get ready to fight! At 13:00, we will run our signature event, Destruction of Dodgy Merchandise (DoDM) in CAGB 103, where we will bid to save or smash dodgy merch frozen in liquid nitrogen. This event is now taking place this year, even after some earlier signs that it might not be possible.

We will then return to RSM 228 for a Q&A panel with our Guests of Honor at 14:00. After this, we will end the day with some trivia, the signature "Turkey Talks" – where you can talk about just whatever you want but remember we can control how long you can speak for via donations – and other smaller events.

Don't forget about the scavenger hunt either, which will be running in parallel throughout the day. Femtocon will also be ongoing, with games borrowed from boardgame society, so look out for that.

I would like to thank you all to coming to Picocon and hope you all have a great time.

ΨΦ

Rajveer Daga
Picocon Sofa

A Word from the Beanbag

Wyrmlholes are many things. A synthesis of wyrms and wormholes. An incredible pun. Dragons tearing open gashes in the space-time fabric of the universe is an inherently awesome (in the biblical sense) image, and a good synthesis between the scifi and fantasy elements of the club. Having been banished to Milton Keynes (a place as monotone as a singularity), I have pondered much on the essence of what a wyrmlhole exactly is... and have come to the revelation that it is, in a word, "cool". Although it has been harder than expected to help from my distant abode, I hope you all enjoy this years Picocon!

ΨΦ

Sam Shenker
Picocon Beanbag

A word from the Editor

Yet again, I would like to thank you all for coming to this year's Picocon.

This will be the third and final year that I am on committee, and it has been a good experience to be able to, each year, contribute to a different part of organising Picocon. As the longest-running committee member present, I feel like some small blame could be attributed to me for various difficulties we've had this year, well, except the ceiling falling in.

I would like to thank everyone who submitted an entry for the Wyrmltongue anthology. For those who are new, this a collection of short stories and artwork, usually related to the year's theme, compiled for you all to read. I hope you enjoy!

ΨΦ

Kai Lam
ICSF Editor

Tabletop Gaming

As usual, Femtocon is running this year, courtesy of the Imperial Tabletop society. All day we will have a selection from our collection of over 200 boardgames available for you to play. Whether you want to relax or test your competitive edge, come find us [wherever the boardgames will be held, likely outside RSM 228] and grab a game or two.

In the Tabletop society, we run weekly sessions for boardgames, RPGs, MTG, and BOTC. So, if you enjoy Femtocon, come check us out on our discord to find session timings. 🎮

Michael Porat
Boardgames Social Secretary & Sci-fi Chair of Vice

Schedule

09:30 Front Desk / registration opens

10:00 Guest Talk: **Drew Wagar**
RSM 228

10:55

11:00 Guest Talk: **Paul McAuley**
RSM 228

11:55

12:00 **LUNCH**
nom nom nom
Baguette Bash

12:55 Queen's Lawn/ Dangoor plaza

13:00 **Destruction of Dodgy Merchandise**
CAGB 103

13:55

14:00 **Guest of Honour Q&A Panel**
RSM 228

14:55

15:00 **Picocon Quiz**
RSM 228

15:45

15:45 **Turkey Talks**
RSM 228

16:30

Guests of Honour

Author of multiple best-selling science fiction and fantasy novels, Drew Wagar has also written novels set in the video-game universes of Elite Dangerous and Lords of Midnight.

Drew also has a Youtube channel under his own name, where he showcases his many interests, with streams and lore videos on Elite Dangerous standing out.

His original work includes the Shadeward and Hegira sagas, each taking place over a galactic scope, backed by a real love for the sci-fi concepts within.



DREW WAGAR

Before writing full-time, Paul McAuley earned a PhD in Botany and worked as a researcher in multiple top British universities.

Over a thirty-year career, he has written multiple award-winning books that showcase his incredible range.

His work includes: Fairyland, winner of both the Arthur C. Clarke and John W. Campbell Awards, a which exploring biohacking and genetic engineering; Cowboy Angels, his ambitious take on alternate history and time-travel; and most recently, Loss Protocol, in which a ranger becomes entangled with a cult that believes the world can be healed through the power of collective dreams.



PAUL MCAULEY

Quest Objectives

This year's teams are (dramatic pause):



Smaug
Wyrms



M87[★]
Wormholes



Worm
Worms

- Items can be submitted to the Front Desk for Fun Points™ after 11am.
- Pictures are (usually) not admissible.
- Objectives involving people must only be undertaken with the person's permission.
- The front desk reserves the right to keep the submitted items.
- Unless otherwise noted, each faction may claim an item on the list only once.

List of mysterious, potentially unfindable items

10	A wyrm ^E		The following holes can be claimed multiple times:
5	A hole ^E		
50	A wyrmhole ^{FD E}	2	Loop
10	A terrible cosplay ^{FD E}	5	Donut ^{FD}
30	A good cosplay ^{FD E}	5	Onion ring
Age+5	Ex-ICSF Chair ^M	10	Mouse
Age+5	Ex-ICSF Librarian ^M	10	Rabbit
Age+5	Ex-ICSF Treasurer ^M	10	Fox
Age+5	Ex-ICSF Editor ^M	15	An explanation of how worm-holes work without using a pencil and a sheet of paper
Age+5	Ex-ICSF Chair of Vice ^M		
Age+5	Ex-ICSF Secretary ^M	5	Pin
Age+5	T-shirts from Picocon's past ^M	10	Bore
10	Previous Guest of Honour ^E	15	A hole-in-one ^{FD}
5	Good news	25	A Hole-y relic ^{FD}
0	Mediocre news	10	A Holy book
-5	Bad news	2	A piece of clothing with holes that aren't meant to be there
2	A funny joke ^{FD E}	10	Something (w)holesome
-2	A bad pun ^{FD E}	1	A piece of hole-related media
100	The Picocon Sofa, calm	10	An explanation of the game Can of Wormholes
50	The Picocon Beanbag, frantic	10	A vortex
20	Snacks generously shared ^{FD E}		The following wyrms can be claimed multiple times:
-15	Snacks selfishly hoarded ^{FD E}		
20	A non-ICSF fresher at Picocon ^E	5	A dragon
20	A completed nonogram ^E	10	A dragon fruit
25	A completed crossword ^E	40	A worm (alive)
3	An understood reference ^E	-10	A worm (dead)
-3	A misunderstood reference ^E	25	Proof of defeat of Astellarn (runes-cape)
-10	A misunderstood scientific reference ^E	1	A piece of wyrm-related media
10	An interesting, relevant factoid ^{FD E}	15	A wyrd sister
30	A bookworm	15	Wormtongue (the guy)
10	A plot hole	5	Wormtail (the rat)
10	The true name of a dragon	No .	List of dragons from any published media ^M
5	A bottle of dragon's breath	10	A won game of Dragonsweeper
10	A treasurer, sarcastic	10	A dragon egg

	Back to our regular, default single claim items	3	Famous last words (subject to checking)
5	A piece of wormhole-related media ^E ^{FD}	-50	per fatality
10	An ouroboros	1d20	A d20 rolled ^M
44	An aura-boros ^E	-1d20	A d20, already dead ^{FD} ^M
2	A mobius strip	19	A 19-torus
33	A Klein bottle	10	A Techpriest, pedantic
22	Other topologically interesting items	10	Donations of any suitably themed abomination ^E
77	An umbilic torus	11	Donations of any suitably themed plastic abomination
200	TARS (Interstellar)	secs	A roar at the front desk, point per second duration ^M
10	A healthy obsession	Mins	An explanation of how time travel works in a piece of media, point per minute ^M
-10	An unhealthy obsession	5	A sleepy editor, double points for explaining the crossword theme
20	A justified financially irresponsible action	5	Spice ^E
-20	An unjustified financially irresponsible action	1000	£100 ^E
5	An assignment submitted before Picocon due after Picocon ^E	50	A vegetable of amusing shape ^E
4.37	A secretary, broken	Mins	A winner of a femtocon game ^{FD} ^E ^M
20	A whole, intact baguette that has survived more than one baguette battle ^E	1000	Our Secretary's upcoming coursework
1	A whole, intact baguette that has cowardly shied away from glorious battle	5	Some wormwood
1	A paper clip	20	A can of worms
2	Famous first words	20	A reference to Worm, the web serial

^{FD} Front Desk Person's Discretion[†]

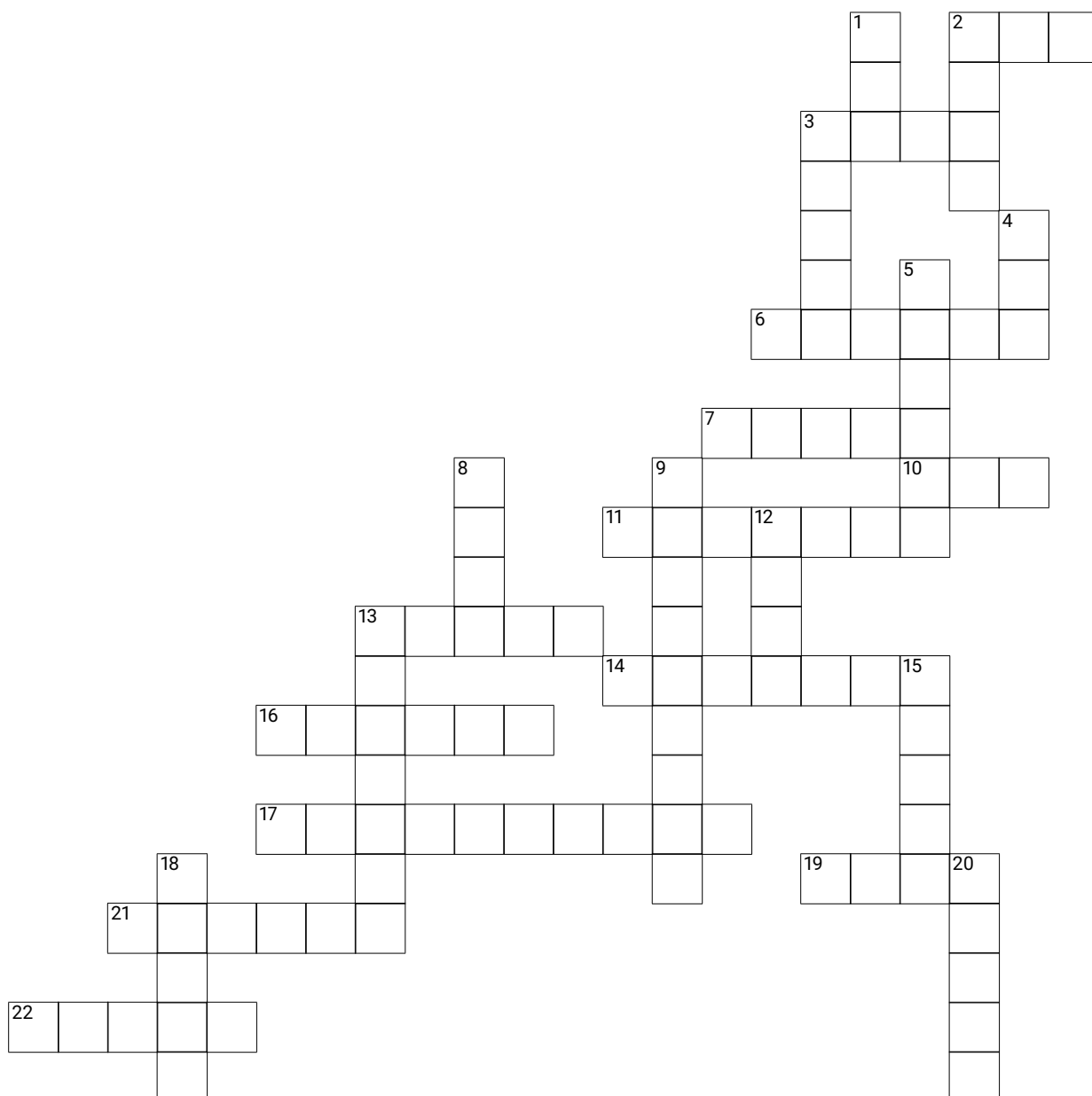
^E This item may be claimed multiple times per faction ("each")

^M For each faction, the highest of their scores will be used

[†]This actually applies to everything; where it is noted, it indicates that you're unlikely to change anyone's mind with your cunning arguments.

[illegible]

Crossword



Crossword Clues

Across

- 2 Personal identification number. (3)
- 3 H-R diagram plots brightness and ____ colour . (4)
- 6 Charizard is a Fire and _____ Type . (6)
- 7 he first book of the Liveship Traders trilogy is the Ship of _____. (5)
- 10 Portal's cake. (3)
- 11 From the movie Iron Lung, the quiet _____ causes the stars to vanish. (7)
- 13 Many-headed snaky monster. (5)
- 14 Electromagnetic ranged weapon. (7)
- 16 Revolving fluid. (6)
- 17 Bird that bores trees for insects. (10)
- 19 Old English term for Beowulf's last enemy. (4)
- 21 Toy that "walks" down stairs. (6)
- 22 Bowled fruit juice or a hit. (5)

Down

- 1 Possible effect of digital media on the brain. (3)
- 2 Planet of dragonriders. (4)
- 3 Discworld dragon breeder. (5)
- 4 Drinking implement topologically equivalent to a donut. (3)
- 5 Yellow line. (6)
- 8 Early ____ catches the worm. (4)
- 9 Dragon-riding family of Westeros. (9)
- 12 Jörmungandr is known for biting its own _____. (4)
- 13 "Eye of _____" (powers the TARDIS). (7)
- 15 Opposite of Zenith. (5)
- 18 The _____ arrow was used to shoot down Smaug. (5)
- 20 Termite home. (5)

Word Search

I D M M E E V A C L E D L M R H R I T N
 I N N O A C I O E O R G O H O R E L O C
 D K A W E A A A E L M F M A E I I D A G
 K N H E R P K E B P W E R H M G L M S B
 T E R O S S Y B A N T D T E E W M D L N
 O E C D N T O N E E E I R D E F L P S I
 T A S E N O T B O R L T P A W E T O P T
 R I D N K R U R L S E O D G K E N R G U
 G W O W R L I S I H A T R V T E E T U S
 E T O I A T E O R E I C E U E L T A R D
 T R M L E G E N D C O D R N O K R L E E
 M I R A E F L V N E E D I E N E R G N O
 P E M F G S O M E D O T A M E N O W D I
 S P I I U E H D T U N N E L E L P T M V
 L R W L O D M I I M R O W D N I L E S
 E K N A G E R L T N E P R E S P S R N T
 E E M N D T O L F P O O D E E M I I E H
 E L A A R U W E I O T L P T V O I D O W
 C N O E V B A W R L E R A H T E N E R N
 E F W B L E N G L L I G O S E T L I L E

ABYSS
 TUNNEL
 FEAR
 NEMATODE
 FIRE
 TENDRIL
 BOOKWORM

RIFT
 WELL
 CAVE
 GOLD
 HOARD
 PORTAL
 VOID

LINDWORM
 PIT
 SPACE
 DRAKE
 LEGEND
 SERPENT
 GOUGE

DEN
 METEORITE
 NEBULA
 GATE
 DIMENSION
 WORMHOLE
 SLITHER

Notes and Stuff

Notes and Stuff

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